17. Our original zest had now quite gone, and it was turning more into a grim struggle. I then realized that the ridge ahead, instead of rising, now dropped sharply away. I looked upwards to see a narrow snow ridge running up to a snowy summit. A few more whacks of the ice-axe in the firm snow and we stood on top.

18. My first feelings were of relief– relief that there were no more steps to cut, no more ridges to **traverse**, and no more humps to **tantalize** us with hopes of success. I looked at Tenzing. In spite of the balaclava helmet, goggles, and oxygen mask – all encrusted with long icicles–that concealed his face, there was no disguising his grin of delight as he looked all around him. We shook hands, and then Tenzing threw his arm around my shoulders and we thumped each other on the back until we were almost breathless. It was 11.30 a.m. The ridge had taken us two and a half hours, but it seemed like a lifetime.

19. To the east was our giant neighbour Makalu, unexplored and unclimbed. Far away across the clouds, the great bulk of Kanchenjunga loomed on the horizon. To the west, we could see the great unexplored ranges of Nepal stretching off into the distance.

20. The most important photograph, I felt, was a shot down the North Ridge, showing the North Col and the old route which had been made famous by the struggles of those great climbers of the 1920's and 1930's. After ten minutes, I realized that I was becoming rather clumsy-fingered and slow-moving. So I quickly replaced my oxygen set.

21. Meanwhile, Tenzing had made a little hole in the snow, and in it he placed various small articles of food– a bar of chocolate, a packet of biscuits, and a handful of lollies. Small offerings, indeed, but at least a token gift to the Gods that all devout Buddhists believe have their home on this lofty summit.

22. While we were together on the South Col two days before, Colonel Hunt had given me a small crucifix which he had asked me to take to the top. I, too, made a hole in the snow and placed the crucifix beside Tenzing's gifts.

23. After fifteen minutes, I moved down off the summit on to our steps. Wasting no time, we **cramponed** along our tracks, spurred by the urgency of diminishing oxygen. We scrambled cautiously over the rock traverse, moved one at a time over shaky snow sections and finally cramponed up our steps and back on to the South Peak.

24. We were now very tired, but moved down to the two reserve cylinders on the ridge. As we were only a short distance from camp, and had a few litres of oxygen left in our own bottles, we carried the extra cylinders down, and reached our tent on its crazy platform at 2 p.m.

25. With a last look at the camp that had served us so well, we turned downwards with dragging feet and set ourselves to the task of safely descending the ridge to the South Col.

26. The time passed as in a dream. Two figures came towards us and met us

12th General_English_Unit_4_A_Prose.indd 114 07-12-2021 18:07:19